Simultaneously, the installation work was begun at the new plant in Gujarat. It was a mammoth task that was seamlessly executed, and Chief Minister Modi inaugurated the Tata Nano plant in Sanand on 2 June 2010.

After the debacle in Singur, it was a welcome relief. Ratan wrote to Modi saying that it was his 'vision and inspiring leadership' that had made it 'possible in a short span of time' to establish the plant. He added that he was 'extremely grateful' to the chief minister for 'making this happen'. And true to what Ratan had said, the Nano brought prosperity to Sanand, which soon earned the sobriquet of the Detroit of India.

Nano's Woes

There were many firsts with the Nano; even the booking mechanism for the car was innovative and unique. For the first time in the Indian automobile industry, customers could book their car online by going to the 'Nano portal'. They could also make online payments through nearly three dozen banks. Tata Motors planned to subsequently extend this to online sales. The portal was so popular that it got more than 30 million hits within a year of its launch.

There were almost 6,000 groups and forums in which news and views on the car were exchanged. The name 'Nano' became a new catchword and the other Tata Group companies created merchandise inspired by it that was sold online. It was the company's first foray into the e-commerce space. The products ranged from the Nano phone (manufactured by Tata Indicom), the Nano watch (Titan) and apparel (Tata Westside) to even the Nano computer mouse (Tata Croma) and much more.

In addition, in a move that leveraged the Tata Group's large reach, its retail stores Croma and Westside displayed the car and accepted bookings. The Titan and Tata Indicom showrooms also sold application forms. This led to further visibility and enhanced customer convenience. Apart from leveraging its own companies, Tata persuaded Amul Butter to carry the Nano image and logo on its packs. The subliminal advertisement took the car directly into Indian homes.

The booking process was also further streamlined. The cash management, inclusive of collection and refunds, was outsourced to the State Bank of India, which gave the company the benefit of additional outlets across 850 cities. Agreements were also reached with fifteen